

MASTERS OF BRICK AND STONE

Africa

Adapting to a wide range of climates, the builders of Africa's man-made wonders have relied on ingenious uses of materials. North of the Sahara, the Nile Valley's limestone and sandstone were the building blocks of ancient temples and pyramid tombs. The Egyptians excelled at crafting stone columns, positioned close together to support heavy loads, which enabled them to build large-scale structures. Some of the continent's best-known architectural achievements are in North Africa, which benefitted not only from easily quarried stone but also from frequent cultural and trade exchanges with other parts of the world. South of the Sahara, the masons of Ethiopia carved entire buildings from solid stone, while other African architects used the earth itself, baked into bricks under the Sun.

KEY SITES

- 1

The Great Sphinx
Pyramids of Giza
- 2

Karnak Temple
Complex
- 3

Abu Simbel Temples
- 4

Meroë Pyramids
- 5

Timagad
- 6

Royal Mausoleum
of Mauretania
- 7

Obelisks and Royal
Tombs of Aksum
- 8

Leptis Magna
- 9

Amphitheater
of El Jem
- 10

Great Mosque
of Kairouan
- 11

Kano City Walls
- 12

Lalibela Rock
Churches
- 13

Koutoubia Mosque
- 14

Great Zimbabwe
- 15

Royal Palaces
of Abomey
- 16

Great Mosque
of Djenné
- 17

Afrikaans Language
Monument
- 18

Basilica of Our
Lady of Peace

ISLAM MOVES WEST

632-681 CE

The movement of Islam toward northeast and northwest Africa sparked a wave of mosque building, with 7th-century examples in Eritrea, Ethiopia, Egypt, Somalia, Tunisia, and Algeria. These early mosques borrowed from the style of the time, with innovations such as square or rectangular rather than circular minarets.



11 GREAT MOSQUE OF KAIROUAN

CHRISTIANITY BRINGS CHURCHES

1ST CENTURY-EARLY 15TH CENTURY

As Christianity spread through the Horn of Africa, places of worship and monasteries were built to cement the Christian presence and attract converts. The stonemasons of Ethiopia applied indigenous tradition with remarkable results in carving the Church of St. George (below) and other churches from solid rock.



13 LALIBELA ROCK CHURCH

THE ROMAN OCCUPATION

146 BCE-698 CE

Wherever the Romans expanded, they introduced their model of city life in order to placate and attract their new subjects, as well as to provide a home for soldiers and expatriate citizens. Even remote outposts such as Timagad display the characteristic Roman grid of streets, with footpaths, colonnades, and public facilities.

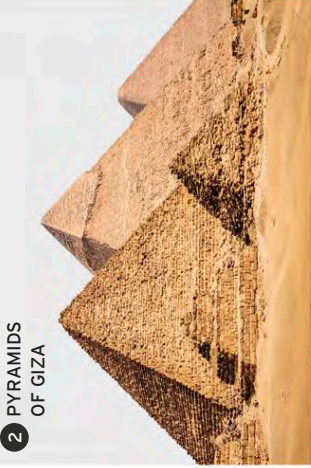


6 TIMGAD

MONUMENTS OF ANCIENT EGYPT

3100-30 BCE

The pyramid was a trademark of Egyptian monument building, but the Egyptians also built with columns and pediments, which were later adopted by the Greeks. They worked with massive blocks of limestone and granite—using no pulleys, iron tools, or the wheel—and also leveled their foundations extremely accurately.



2 PYRAMIDS OF GIZA

the Great Mosque of Kairouan was established in 670CE and is the oldest place of Muslim worship in Africa

the pyramids of Giza are the only surviving Wonders of the Ancient World

